

Theme and Mood in Culturally Equivalent Proverbs: Grammatical Mood as a Reflection of Social

Attitude

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Abstract

This study compares equivalent proverbs in English (eng), Persian (fas), and Spanish (spa) using Halliday's (1994) SYSTEMIC FUNCTIONAL GRAMMAR (SFG). The motivation is twofold: first, while comparative studies using SFG exist, none address proverbs across these three languages; second, SFG offers an effective framework for analyzing clause structures and linguistic similarities. The hypothesis assumes that equivalent proverbs should be syntactically and pragmatically similar, despite structural and cultural differences. The corpus comprises 774 proverbs—258 from each language—sourced from monolingual dictionaries. Analysis focuses on two METAFUNCTIONS: INTERPERSONAL and TEXTUAL. INTERPERSONAL findings reveal that all three languages favor declarative clauses, indicating an informational orientation and pragmatic equivalence. TEXTUAL analysis shows greater syntactic proximity between English and Persian, particularly in Theme types. Overall, while pragmatic patterns are consistent across the corpora, English and Persian demonstrate stronger SYNTACTIC ALIGNMENT.

Keywords proverb analysis. SYSTEMIC FUNCTIONAL GRAMMAR. SYNTAX-PRAGMATICS INTERFACE. English.

Persian. Spanish

Abbreviation

2	second person
3	third person
DOM ¹	direct object marker
IMP	imperative
M	masculine
O	object
POSS	possessive

¹ DOM stands for DIRECT OBJECT MARKER. In Persian an object NP is generally followed by a DIRECT OBJECT MARKER (DOM) *raa*.

PRS	present
PST	past
Q	question mark
S	subject
SBJV	subjunctive mood
SG	singular

1. Introduction

PAREMIOLOGY, the study of proverb features, structure, and functions, often supports interlingual and intralingual comparisons. Closely linked to PAREMIOGRAPHY—the collection of proverbs—PAREMIOLOGISTS rely on compiled sources, sometimes serving as PAREMIOGRAPHERS themselves. In this study, the researcher consulted monolingual dictionaries in Persian, English, and Spanish to identify equivalents, drawing from the most widely cited proverbial sources.

This study compares Persian proverbs with their English and Spanish equivalents through the lens of the three METAFUNCTIONS in SYSTEMIC FUNCTIONAL LINGUISTICS (SFL) / SYSTEMIC FUNCTIONAL GRAMMAR (SFG), a framework introduced by M. A. K. Halliday and later developed with linguists such as Suzanne Eggins, Ruqaiya Hasan, James R. Martin, and Christian M. I. M. Matthiessen (Halliday 1967; 1968; 1975; 1978; 1985 & 1994; Halliday & Hasan 1976; Halliday & Matthiessen 2004; Hasan 1984; 1985; Eggins 2004; Martin 1992; Matthiessen 1995; 2009). This linguistic model offers three systems (TRANSITIVITY, MOOD, and THEME) to explore the three METAFUNCTIONS that operate simultaneously in all linguistic expressions, reflecting different aspects of communication, and facilitating clause analysis in terms of its SEMANTIC

CONTENT, PRAGMATIC CONTRIBUTION, and SYNTACTIC STRUCTURE. However, this study only implements two out of the three systems namely, MOOD and THEME.

The scarcity of research dealing with the analysis of proverbs within the framework of SFG and the lack of studies dealing specifically with the proverbs of three Indo-European languages, English, Persian, and Spanish, motivated their examination into their shared common properties. A few previous research works have made similar grammatical comparative analyses, such as McCabe (1999), Mohammadi & Nabifar (2012), Rodríguez Arancón (2013), Dabbagh & Noshadi (2015), Akabuike (2020), Emodi (2021), & Emodi & Okeke (2022), which were carried out based on the SFG framework. However, among all the aforementioned studies that were done on the first METAFUNCTION of the SFG, only McCabe (1999) was carried out on the INTERPERSONAL and TEXTUAL METAFUNCTION, which are the focus of this study.

There are two factors to consider in terms of the sampling gap, one being the GENRE of the data under investigation, namely proverbs, and another being the number of languages involved in the study. The data analysed in McCabe's study were 1,496 clauses of historical textbooks in English and Spanish. Moreover, in her INTERPERSONAL ANALYSIS, McCabe (1999) placed greater emphasis on the use of MODAL ADJUNCTS rather than on the four MOOD TYPES of a clause, namely DECLARATIVE, IMPERATIVE, WH-INTERROGATIVE and YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE. Another difference lies in the fact that she did not take into account certain types of THEME, such as the MULTIPLE THEME. McCabe's study also considers SUBJECT and COMPLEMENT as THEME TYPES but both are labelled under a single term, namely NOMINAL GROUP, in the present study. Likewise, she considers CIRCUMSTANCE as another THEME TYPE but it may correspond to either ADVERBIAL GROUP or PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE in this study.

The general aim of this study is to compare the structure and the use of proverbs in Persian, English, and Spanish in order to find which properties they have in common. This study will therefore carry out a trilingual comparison of 774 equivalent proverbs, with the SYSTEMIC FUNCTIONAL GRAMMAR (SFG) as the linguistic model used to compare their grammatical structure and content, as it facilitates the SYNTACTIC and PRAGMATIC

analysis of data through two systems of THEME and MOOD, in such a way as to pave the way for CLAUSAL ANALYSIS.

To achieve this aim a number of specific objectives must be reached such as: 1) computing the ratio of the DECLARATIVE, IMPERATIVE, and INTERROGATIVE mood clauses in proverbs in the three languages detected in the MOOD (SUBJECT and FINITE) of the MOOD SYSTEM; 2) calculating the ratio of the different THEME TYPES that are distinguished by the THEME SYSTEM in the proverbs of the three languages; and finally, 3) comparing the data obtained from the analysis of proverbs in Spanish, English and Persian. Once these objectives have been achieved, the HYPOTHESES of this study will be discussed.

This study is based on three HYPOTHESES concerning the relationship between 3 languages, that is Persian, English and Spanish, and two specific VARIABLES explored in the SFG grammatical model, namely MOOD TYPES and THEME TYPES. The first HYPOTHESIS investigates whether the equivalent proverbs use the same INTERACTIONAL MOVES based on the MOOD SYSTEM to have the same effect on their hearers. The second HYPOTHESIS examines whether speakers of different languages use similar structural operations to characterize the FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION of CLAUSE STRUCTURE, as reflected in the THEME SYSTEM. The last HYPOTHESIS deals with the similarities and differences of the proverbs in question to decide whether they are indicative of LINGUISTIC as well as CULTURAL DIFFERENCES. These HYPOTHESES are as follows:

H1. Languages also have resources for enacting the diverse and complex social relations between human beings (INTERPERSONAL METAFUNCTION), which is manifested in the SYSTEM OF MOOD, and equivalent proverbs used in different languages tend to represent the same interaction between speaker and addressee. So, it would seem plausible to assume that they make similar use of GRAMMATICAL RESOURCES to realize the INTERACTIONAL MOVES in a specific discourse in order to achieve the same effect on their hearers.

H2. Given that INTERPERSONAL MEANINGS constitute information to be shared by speakers and hearers in the form of text unfolding in context (TEXTUAL METAFUNCTION), speakers of different languages will probably use similar structural operations to characterize the FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION of CLAUSAL

STRUCTURE – reflected in the system of THEME – more specifically to express equivalent proverbs and guide the listener in his/her interpretation of a text.

H3. Taking into account the fact that this study offers a CONTRASTIVE ANALYSIS of equivalent proverbs in three different languages, it would seem logical that the differences observed with respect to the two SYSTEMS should not only reflect LINGUISTIC but also CULTURAL DIFFERENCES.

In other words, the objective of this study is basically twofold. Firstly, to ascertain whether the equivalent proverbs use the same INTERACTIONAL MOOD to refer to their hearer. And secondly, to see whether these equivalent proverbs use similar STRUCTURAL OPERATIONS to characterize the FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION of CLAUSE STRUCTURE. In order to achieve the objectives of the study, a number of specific research questions (RQs) were considered:

RQ1. Do equivalent proverbs in different languages represent an interaction between the speaker and hearer in a similar manner?

RQ2. Is the information contained in a sentence organized in a similar manner in equivalent proverbs in different languages?

RQ3. Does a comparison of equivalent proverbs in different languages also reflect SOCIOCULTURAL SIMILARITIES AND DIFFERENCES?

As a starting point for the analysis conducted in this research study, it seems logical to include an examination of a significant grammatical feature in the three languages, namely their CANONICAL WORD ORDER, due to the implications it may have for the analysis conducted in this study.

WORD ORDER TYPOLOGY is a criterion of LANGUAGE TYPOLOGY that deals with the order of CLAUSAL CONSTITUENTS in the world's languages (Greenberg 1963; Comrie 1989).² There are six types of word order

² The reason for mentioning the WORD ORDER TYPOLOGY is to bring to attention the fact that one of the languages included in this study (Persian) is SYNTACTICALLY different from the other two (English and

for languages (SOV, SVO, VSO, VOS, OVS, and OSV) among which the first three are more common, the first two in particular. The following paragraph explores the word order of the three languages under study here.

Persian is one of the ten oldest languages still spoken in the world today, with roots dating back to the Persian Empire of the 6th century B.C. Persian, also known by its endonym *FARSI*, belongs to the Indo-European language category. It is spoken in Iran, Afghanistan, and Tajikistan. As Persian is an ANALYTIC LANGUAGE, its word order is relatively inflexible because it serves to identify which element of the sentence is the subject and which is the object. The CANONICAL WORD ORDER in this language is the SOV (1) but the SVO word order (2) can also be observed in informal and spoken Persian (Dabir-Moghaddam 2018):

- علی غذایش را خورد.
- (1) Ali *ghazaayash* *raa* *khord*.
 Ali POSS.3SG.food DOM eat.PST.3SG.S
 ‘Ali ate his food.’ (Lit. ‘Ali *his food ate*.’)
- علی خورد غذایش را.
- (2) Ali *khord* *ghazaayash* *raa*.
 Ali eat.PST.3SG.S POSS.3SG.food DOM
 ‘Ali ate his food.’ (Lit. ‘Ali *ate his food*.’)

English is also an instance of ANALYTIC LANGUAGE with a quite rigid word order but, unlike in Persian, the CANONICAL WORD ORDER in English is SVO. With the exception of a few constructions that exhibit an INVERSION between the subject and the verb, any other CONSTITUENT ORDER would entail altering the meaning of the sentence. For example, ‘The dog bit John’ and ‘John bit the dog’ mean two completely different things.

While Spanish also has ANALYTIC FEATURES, it can be considered more SYNTHETIC than Persian and English, as relies more on INFLECTION to express GRAMMATICAL RELATIONSHIPS, such as tense, mood, person, number, and gender. This means that, although the most frequent word order pattern in this language is SVO, its CLAUSAL CONSTITUENTS exhibit greater positional flexibility, which allows the same sentence to be

Spanish), which might have implications for the COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS undertaken in the research, especially in the THEME SYSTEM.

expressed with different word orders, each reflecting distinct DISCOURSE-PRAGMATIC PROPERTIES. For instance, a sentence like *El perro mordió a Juan* ‘The dog bit John’, has the same meaning as other different sentences such as *A Juan lo mordió el perro*, *A Juan el perro lo mordió*, *Mordió el perro a Juan*, or *Mordió a Juan el perro*.

The paper is structured as follows: Section 2 outlines the methodology, detailing the data collection procedure, materials, tools, and the approach to data analysis. Section 3 presents the results through tables and figures, accompanied by explanatory commentary. Section 4 discusses the findings in relation to each research question. Section 5 concludes the study by highlighting its implications and suggesting directions for future research.

2. Methodology

This research seeks to compare a trilingual body of proverbs based on the MOOD and THEME SYSTEMS outlined in the SFG (Halliday 1985; 1994; 2004; 2014; among others). Its collected data, namely proverbs, are the primary data because they were collected directly from main sources such as published proverb dictionaries in each of the three languages and online multilingual proverb dictionaries. A MIXED METHODS approach is used here since it contains both QUANTITATIVE and QUALITATIVE data. The proverbs are compared SYNTACTICALLY and PRAGMATICALLY in relation to the systems associated with the METAFUNCTIONS in SFG, namely the MOOD SYSTEM and the THEME SYSTEM. Persian, English, and Spanish were selected as the three languages for this COMPARATIVE STUDY of proverbs due to my native proficiency in Persian and advanced command of both English and Spanish. The data selection focused on general proverbs that advocate wisdom, promote knowledge, emphasize ethical values, or warn against ignorance, among other universally relevant themes.

In the initial stage, I compiled 1,325 Persian proverbs and began identifying their English and Spanish equivalents using respective proverb dictionaries. Not all had matches in both languages, reducing the list to

416 proverbs with equivalents in English and Spanish. This was further narrowed to 258 Persian proverbs (774 total) due to variations in T-UNIT counts,³ which were used as the UNIT OF ANALYSIS. Data collection was manual, and entries were recorded in an Excel file with four columns: Persian proverb, free translation, English equivalent, and Spanish equivalent.

The data were collected in the following order: Persian, English, and then Spanish. As regards the Persian data, although different sources were consulted, the major body of data was chosen from the very famous Persian dictionary of proverbs *Amsaal o Hekam*, which was written by Ali Akbar Dehkhoda in 1984. The second most consulted dictionary of Persian proverbs was *Qand o Namak*, written by Jafar Shahri in 2021. Proverb dictionaries such as *Farhang Bozorg Zarbolmasalha-ye Farsi*, written by Hasan Zou Alfaghari in 2009, and *Majma ol Amsaal*, written by Mohammad Ali Hableroudi in 1965, were among the other sources consulted in this research.

For the English proverbs, I endeavoured to gather only the proverbs that were originally from the United States or the United Kingdom. The dictionaries of English proverbs in order of the most consulted to the least consulted are as follows: *Early American Proverbs and Proverbial Phrases*, written by Bartlett Jere Whiting in 1977, *A Dictionary of American Proverbs*, edited by Wolfgang Mieder, Stewart A. Kingsbury, & Kelsie B. Harder in 1992, *Dictionary of Authentic American Proverbs* written by Wolfgang Mieder in 2021, *Oxford Dictionary of Proverbs*, written by John Simpson & Jennifer Speake in 2002, and *The Wordsworth Dictionary of Proverbs*, written by Apperson in 1993.

The following famous collections of Spanish proverbs furnished the final data to be collected: *Diccionario de Refranes, Adagios, Refranes, Modismos, Locuciones y Frases proverbiales de la Lengua Española*, which was written by Jose María Sbarbi y Osuna, and published posthumously by Manuel José García in Madrid in 1922, and *Vocabulario de Refranes y Frases Proverbiales* written by Gonzalo Correas in

³ A T-UNIT is any INDEPENDENT or MAIN CLAUSE with all its SUBORDINATE CLAUSES embedded in it (Hunt 1977).

1924. A considerable quantity of data was collected from an online multilingual platform of proverbs called *El Refranero Multilingue* belonging to the Cervantes Institute, which was launched by Julia Sevilla Muñoz and María Teresa Zurdo Ruiz-Ayúcar in 2009.

Once the proverbs were collected in an EXCEL file, their GRAMMATICAL CONSTRUCTION was analysed according to two systems associated with the SFG METAFUNCTIONS in a two-row table like those illustrated in Tables 1, 2, and 3 below. Subsequently, the analysis was stored in three separate Word files, each pertaining to one of the three languages. As regards the analysis, each METAFUNCTION facilitated a different system, namely, the MOOD SYSTEM and the THEME SYSTEM, respectively, which provided a deeper insight into the PRAGMATIC and SYNTACTIC properties of the proverbs in this research. Each Word file presented proverbs in a table, broken into two parallel rows—one per system. The first row analyzed the MOOD SYSTEM, separating the MOOD (SUBJECT and FINITE) from the RESIDUE (PREDICATOR, COMPLEMENT, ADJUNCT). The SUBJECT–FINITE order helped identify clause moods such as DECLARATIVE, IMPERATIVE, WH-INTERROGATIVE, and YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE. The second part of the table addressed the THEME SYSTEM, in which the THEME was distinguished from the RHEME, with the obligatory presence of an IDEATIONAL ELEMENT (PARTICIPANT, PROCESS, or CIRCUMSTANCE) within the THEME. An example of how the analysis of proverbs in each language was conducted is provided below.

Table 1. An example of an analysis of an English proverb based on two SYSTEMS associated with two METAFUNCTIONS

System	A little fire may kindle a great matter.				
—	A little fire	may	kindle	a great matter	
—	Subject	Finite	Predicator	Complement	
MOOD	Mood		Residue		
—	Topical Theme	—			
THEME	Theme	Rheme			

Table 2. An example of an analysis of a Persian proverb based on two SYSTEMS associated with two METAFUNCTIONS

System	آدم به امید زنده است.			
—	<i>Aadam be omid zende h ast. ‘Hope keeps man alive’ (Lit. ‘Man with hope alive is.’)</i>			
—	Aadam	be omid	zende h	ast
—	Subject	Adjunct: circ	Complement	Finite
MOOD	Mood	Residue		Mood
—	Topical Theme	—		
THEME	Theme	Rheme		

Table 3. An example of an analysis of a Spanish proverb based on two SYSTEMS associated with two METAFUNCTIONS

System	<i>La desconfianza aparta el engaño. ‘Distrust drives away deception’</i>		
—	La desconfianza	aparta	el engaño
—	Subject	Predicator	Complement
MOOD	Mood	Residue	
—	Topical Theme	—	
THEME	Theme	Rheme	

As is shown in Tables 1, 2 and 3, each proverb was analysed in two parallel rows, which correspond to two different SYSTEMS proposed by SFG. In each row, each proverb was broken down into different constituents. Firstly, the proverbs were analysed through the MOOD SYSTEM of the INTERPERSONAL METAFUNCTION by highlighting the MOOD and RESIDUE of the clause. In this way, the MOOD was marked as containing the SUBJECT and the FINITE VERB, and the RESIDUE as containing the PREDICATOR, the COMPLEMENT, and the ADJUNCT(s), but the most relevant constituent of the MOOD SYSTEM in this study is MOOD, since the type and order in which SUBJECT and FINITE were presented determines the clause mood, namely DECLARATIVE, YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE, WH-INTERROGATIVE, and IMPERATIVE. This information helps us to answer the first RESEARCH QUESTION (RQ1):

RQ1: Do equivalent proverbs in different languages represent the interaction between the speaker and hearer in an analogous way?

To address RQ1, an identification of the different TYPES OF MOOD was first made. Thus, the proverbs in which the order of MOOD elements was SUBJECT + FINITE verb were considered DECLARATIVE. Then, two types of clause were distinguished for the IMPERATIVE MOOD. One was the NEGATIVE IMPERATIVE CLAUSE, in which the SUBJECT is generally implicit, and the order of presentation of the clause elements was (SUBJECT)

+ FINITE VERB+ NOT + VERB. The other was the AFFIRMATIVE IMPERATIVE CLAUSE, in which the SUBJECT also tends to be omitted, no FINITE ELEMENT appears, and the clause elements follow the order (SUBJECT) + VERB. After this, the clauses in which the FINITE VERB preceded the SUBJECT were put into the category of YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE MOOD. Finally, any clause starting with a WH-QUESTION WORD, such as ‘WHO’, ‘WHAT’, ‘WHEN’, ‘WHERE’, ‘WHY’, etc., was marked for WH-INTERROGATIVE MOOD.

The second part of the analysis scrutinized each proverb by marking its THEME and RHEME according to the THEME SYSTEM of the TEXTUAL METAFUNCTION. The THEME selection in this study is based on what Halliday and Matthiessen said about the THEME as the beginning part of a clause that the addresser “*has chosen to highlight as the starting point for the addressee*” (2014: 89). According to Hallidayan theory, a CLAUSE’S THEME ends with the first EXPERIENTIAL ELEMENT—PARTICIPANT, PROCESS, or CIRCUMSTANCE—termed the TOPICAL THEME. Separating THEME and RHEME enabled the labeling of THEME TYPES (e.g., CLAUSE, PREDICATED THEME, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE, NOMINAL GROUP). This aimed to test Halliday and Matthiessen’s claim that “*The most common type of THEME is a PARTICIPANT, realized by a NOMINAL GROUP*” (2014: 91).

RQ2: Do equivalent proverbs in different languages organize the information within the sentence in the same way?

Firstly, to address the RQ2, after separating the THEME from the RHEME in every clause, the THEME TYPE of the clause was identified. This research considered eleven diverse types of THEME: NOMINAL GROUP, PROCESS, CLAUSE, ADVERBIAL GROUP, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE, THERE, THEMATIC EQUATIVE, PREDICATED THEME, EXTRAPOSITION, MULTIPLE THEME, and WH-ELEMENT, which are discussed in Halliday and Matthiessen (2014). In this research, the THEMES were grouped into three categories: 1. ‘Type of element that realizes the THEME’ (NOMINAL GROUP as a PARTICIPANT; ADVERBIAL GROUP, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE, and WH-INTERROGATIVE as CIRCUMSTANCE; and VERBAL GROUP as PROCESS); 2. ‘Type of THEME in terms of simplicity’ (such as MULTIPLE THEME and CLAUSE); and 3. ‘Type of THEME in terms of construction’ (such as THEMATIC EQUATIVE, PREDICATED THEME, EXTRAPOSITION ‘IT’, and EXISTENTIAL ‘THERE’). Once the THEME

of the clause was ascertained, whatever appeared after the THEME was called the RHEME, that is to say the remaining part of the clause. This study also examines the distribution of elements of the TRANSITIVITY SYSTEM (PARTICIPANTS, PROCESSES, and CIRCUMSTANCES) within the RHEME of the clauses expressing the proverbs.

All these steps contributed to answering the third RESEARCH QUESTION (RQ3) of this study:

RQ3: How do differences in THEMATIC PROGRESSION and MOOD REALIZATION contribute to SOCIOCULTURAL VARIATION in proverb interpretation?

To address RQ3, the two systems contributed to making a LINGUISTIC COMPARISON of the proverbs in terms of their SYNTACTIC and PRAGMATIC STRUCTURES. In addition, the proverbs were compared to check for SOCIOCULTURAL SIMILARITIES and DIFFERENCES.

The final stage of analysis involved running a CHI-SQUARE TEST to determine whether significant relationships existed between the proverbs in the three languages and the MOOD and THEME SYSTEMS. This test assessed the acceptance or rejection of the study's three HYPOTHESES concerning CLAUSE MOODS and THEME TYPES. Chosen for its common use in comparing multiple variables, the CHI-SQUARE TEST was conducted using EXCEL.

Challenges in DATA COLLECTION and ANALYSIS are common in SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH. A key issue in this study was the presence of proverbs with more than one T-UNIT, which made comparison across equivalents unfeasible and reduced the list from 1,325 to 258 per language. Another difficulty involved PROVERBIAL PHRASES lacking verbs, as the analysis required clausal forms with both SUBJECTS and VERBS. Rather than excluding these, I added the missing verb. The same approach was applied to MINOR CLAUSES missing a VERB or other elements.⁴ Below are examples of such adjusted phrases and clauses.

⁴ MINOR CLAUSES have no MOOD, no TRANSITIVITY STRUCTURE, and no THEMATIC STRUCTURE. They usually function as call, greetings, alarms, and exclamations like 'John!', 'Good morning!', 'Well done!' or 'Look out!' (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 127).

(3) First come, first served.

In this example, which means that people who arrive earliest get served or treated before people who arrive later, what is missing is a VERB. For this reason, the be VERB 'is' was inserted into its structure to make it possible for the clause to have a VERB, in this case, a TO BE VERB. As a result of this, THE CLAUSE changed into 'First come (is) first served'. Then, the relevant participants of THIS CLAUSE are the two NOMINAL GROUPS 'first come' and 'first served', respectively, among which, the first one is the THEME of the CLAUSE.

(4) To make a mountain of a molehill.

In this example, which means to exaggerate or overreact to a minor or insignificant issue, as the VERB appears in a NON-FINITE FORM (the full INFINITIVE), there is no SUBJECT. Consequently, the CLAUSE was transformed into 'One makes a mountain out of a molehill' by introducing the pronominal SUBJECT 'one' as the THEME and making the VERB finite ('makes') in order to enable the analysis of this instance of DECLARATIVE MOOD.

(5) Better be envied than pitied.

In this example, which means it is preferable to be in a desirable position admired by others, three constituents are missing: a DUMMY SUBJECT 'it', the COPULA 'is', and the PARTICLE OF INFINITIVE 'to' accompanying the AUXILIARY VERB 'be'. By adding the missing elements, the CLAUSE changes into a PREDICATED THEME like 'It is better to be envied than pitied'. In this case, 'It' is the SUBJECT and the THEME, the VERB 'is' functions as the TO BE VERB. The MOOD of this CLAUSE is DECLARATIVE.

In conclusion, this research outlines the methodology used to examine proverbs in three languages through two SFG METAFUNCTIONS. It details the BIBLIOGRAPHIC SOURCES for the CORPUS, the DATA COLLECTION and ANALYSIS PROCEDURES aligned with each RESEARCH QUESTION, and the STATISTICAL APPROACH using CHI-SQUARE TESTS to provide quantitative support. Lastly, it addresses the challenges encountered in ensuring accurate analysis.

3. Results

The analysis presented here involves a SYNTACTIC and PRAGMATIC comparison of the proverbs under investigation, examining how they function in terms of INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION and the roles of the speaker and the listener within the CONTEXT of each proverb as well as the orientation of the message in their clause in terms of THEME/RHEME.

3.1 Mood types

The following indicates the use of the MOOD TYPES in English, Persian, and Spanish, with some examples drawn from their respective CORPORA. Four different mood types were considered in this study such as DECLARATIVE, IMPERATIVE, WH-INTERROGATIVE, and YES/NO INTERROGATIVE.

- (6) A dog barks against the moon. (DECLARATIVE)

ادب از که آموختی؟

- (7) *Adab* *az* *ke* *amookhti?*
manners from who learn.PST.2SG.S.Q

‘Who did you learn manners from?’ (Lit. ‘*Manners from who/whom (you) learned?*’) (WH-INTERROGATIVE)

- (8) *A* *moro* *viejo* *no* *le* *aprendas* *algarabía.*
to Arab old not 3SG.M.O teach.IMP.2SG.S Arabic

‘Don’t teach Arabic to an old Arab.’ (Lit. ‘*To Arab old no him teach Arabic.*’) (IMPERATIVE)

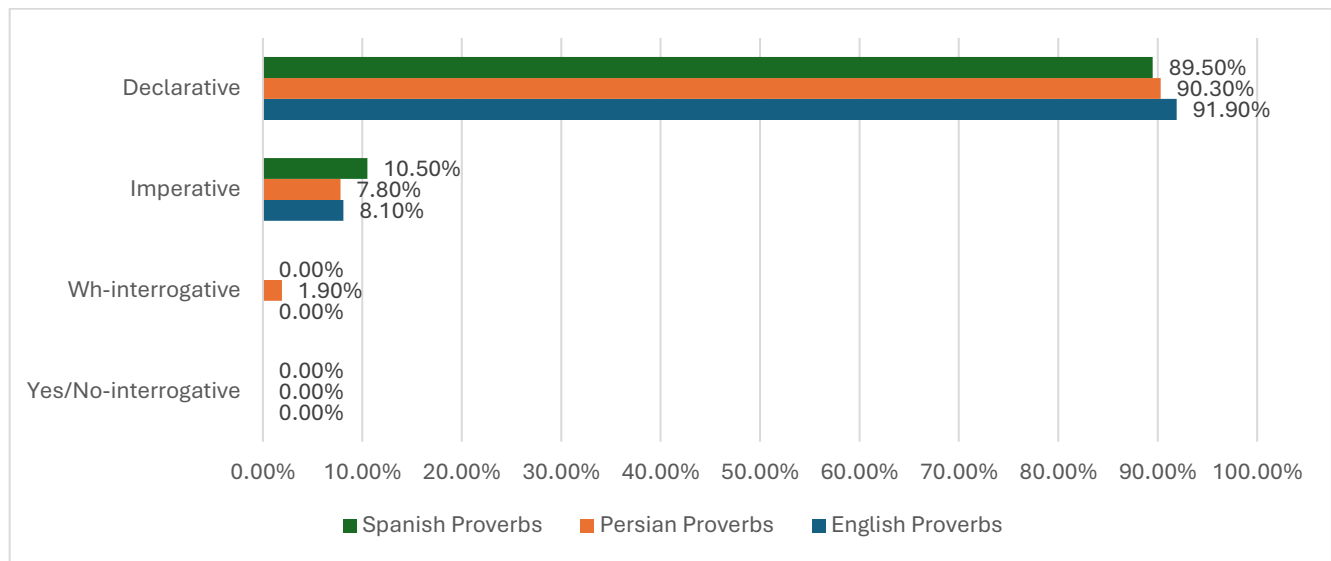


Figure 1. Comparative ratio of the MOOD TYPES across the three languages

If we compare the MOOD TYPE across the three CORPORA shown on Table 4 and Fig. 1, we notice that the proverbs were mainly DECLARATIVE (91.9%, N = 237 in English, 90.3%, N = 233 in Persian, and 89.5%, N = 231 in Spanish, respectively). The second most frequent MOOD TYPE in all three languages was the IMPERATIVE (8.1%, N = 21 in English, 7.8%, N = 20 in Persian, and 10.5%, N = 27 in Spanish, respectively), which shows a considerable decrease from the DECLARATIVE MOOD in the three CORPORA. It is also of note that WH-INTERROGATIVE MOOD was only encountered in the Persian CORPUS (1.9%, N = 5), and that there were no YES/NO-INTERROGATIVES recorded in any of the CORPORA.

Table 4. Comparative relative frequency of the MOOD TYPES across the three languages

MOOD Types	English Proverbs	Percentage	Persian Proverbs	Percentage	Spanish Proverbs	Percentage	Total Items	Total
Declarative	237	91.9%	233	90.3%	231	89.5%	701	90.6%
Imperative	21	8.1%	20	7.8%	27	10.5%	68	8.8%
Wh- interrogative	0	0.0%	5	1.9%	0	0.0%	5	0.6%
Yes/No- interrogative	0	0.0%	0	0.0%	0	0.0%	0	0.0%
Total	258	100.0%	258	100.0%	258	100.0%	774	100%

The results indicate a predominant use of the DECLARATIVE MOOD TYPE, accounting for 90.6% of the total instances across the CORPUS. This suggests that statements are the most common form of interaction in the data. The IMPERATIVE MOOD follows with 8.8%, indicating a moderate frequency of commands or requests. The WH-INTERROGATIVE MOOD TYPE, used for information-seeking questions, appears only sporadically, while there are no occurrences of the YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE MOOD TYPE in this particular corpus. These findings highlight a significant skew towards DECLARATIVE STRUCTURES, with limited use of INTERROGATIVE forms.

The CHI-SQUARE TEST OF INDEPENDENCE indicated a significant relationship between language and MOOD TYPE ($\chi^2 = 11.773992 > \chi^2 \text{ CRITICAL} = 9.488$), leading to the rejection of the NULL HYPOTHESIS. However, PAIRWISE TESTS showed no significant link between English and Spanish ($\chi^2 = 4.248336 < \chi^2 \text{ CRITICAL} = 5.991$), possibly due to differing frequency counts. In contrast, significant associations were found between English and Persian ($\chi^2 = 9.288417$) and Persian and Spanish ($\chi^2 = 10.01123$), both exceeding the CRITICAL VALUE.

This study is unique in its investigation of MOOD TYPES, as no other studies have addressed this aspect of the MOOD SYSTEM interlingually. Consequently, it has not been possible to compare the findings of this study with those of other research. Due to this, the lack of similar analyses in the existing literature on MOOD TYPES limits the ability to place these results in a broader COMPARATIVE CONTEXT.

3.2 Theme types

This section analyzes the THEME SYSTEM, which governs clause structure and information flow. By examining THEME ORGANIZATION, the study explores how different languages shape SENTENCE-LEVEL COHERENCE AND COHESION. Understanding THEME is key to analyzing SYNTACTIC and PRAGMATIC FUNCTIONS in discourse. Eleven THEME TYPES were analyzed across the three corpora: NOMINAL GROUP, PROCESS, CLAUSE, ADVERBIAL GROUP, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE, ‘THERE’, THEMATIC EQUATIVE, PREDICATED THEME, ‘IT’-EXTRAPOSITION, MULTIPLE THEME, and WH-ELEMENT. Some types were absent from some CORPORA, as shown in Fig. 2 and Table 5. In the examples below, THEMES are highlighted in bold, with their type noted in parentheses after each proverb.

- (9) **Standing waters** are most apt to corrupt. (NOMINAL GROUP)
- (10) **He that cannot obey** cannot command. (CLAUSE)
- (11) **Don’t play** with edged tools. (PROCESS)
- (12) **There** is a sucker born every minute. (‘THERE’)
- (13) **It** is better **be envied than pitied**. (EXTRAPOSITION)
- (14) **Never** look a gift horse in the mouth. (ADVERBIAL GROUP)
- (15) **After joy** comes sorrow. (PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE)
- (16) **Gaah** **baashad** *ke koodaki naadaan be*
sometimes be.SBJV.3SG.S that child ignorant by
khataa bar hadaf zanad tiri.
mistake to target hit.PRS.3SG.S arrow
‘Sometimes a simple child might hit the target by chance.’ (Lit. ‘*Sometimes be that a child ignorant by mistake to target hits an arrow.*’) (MULTIPLE THEME)
- (17) **Cheraa** *aaghel konad kaari ke baaz*
why wise do.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S something that back
aarad pashimaani.
bring.PRS.3SG.S regret
‘Why would a wise man do something that he regrets?’ (Lit. ‘*Why wise does something that back brings regret.*’) (WH-ELEMENT)
- (18) **No** *es oro todo lo que reluce.*
not be.3SG.PRS.S gold all the that glitter.PRS.3SG.S
‘All that glitters is not gold.’ (Lit. ‘*Not is gold all that which glitters.*’) (PREDICATED THEME)
- (19) **La esperanza** *es lo último que se*
the hope be.PRS.3SG.S the last that REFL
pierde
lose.PST.3SG.S
‘Hope is the last thing that is lost.’ (Lit. ‘*The hope is that last that is lost.*’) (THEMATIC EQUATIVE)

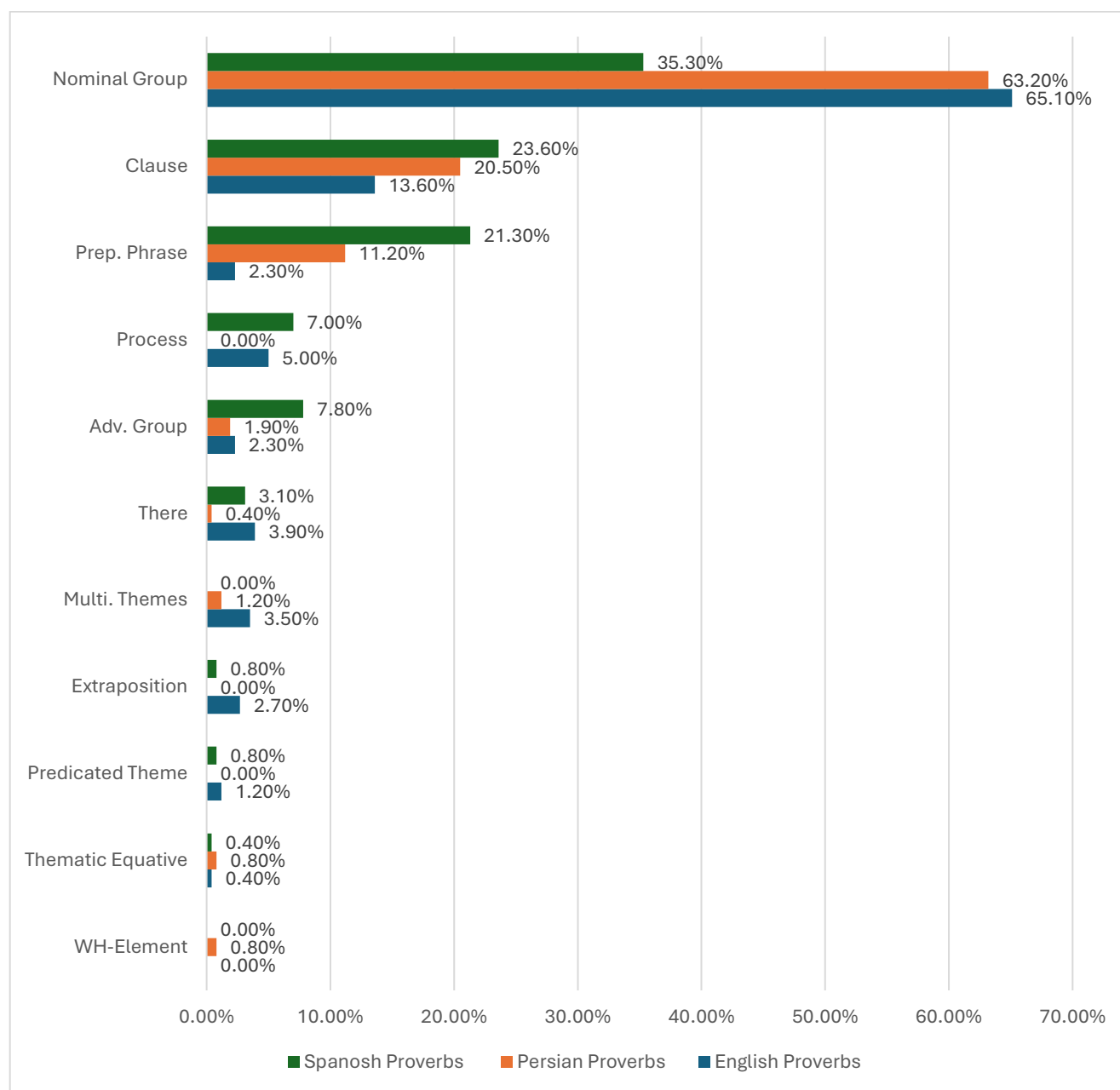


Figure 2. Comparative ratio of the THEME TYPES across the three languages

A comparison of the THEME TYPES across the three corpora (Fig. 2 and Table 5) showed that the NOMINAL GROUP (65.1%, N = 168 in English, 63.2%, N = 163 in Persian, and 35.3%, N = 91 in Spanish) was the most dominant followed by CLAUSE (13.6%, N = 35 in English, 20.5%, N = 53 in Persian, and 23.6%, N = 61 in Spanish) in the three CORPORA. As regards the remaining THEME TYPES, there was no similarity between the three languages. In the English corpus, after NOMINAL GROUP and CLAUSE appear PROCESS (5.0%, N = 13),

‘THERE’ (3.9%, N = 10), MULTIPLE THEME (3.5%, N = 9), EXTRAPOSITION (2.7%, N = 7), ADVERBIAL GROUP, and PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE (2.3%, N = 6) equally, PREDICATED THEME (1.2%, N = 3), and, finally, THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.4%, N = 1). In the Persian corpus the order from the third place onwards was: PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE (11.2%, N = 29), ADVERBIAL GROUP (1.9%, N = 5), MULTIPLE THEME (1.2%, N = 3), WH-ELEMENT (0.8%, N = 2), ‘THERE’ and THEMATIC EQUATIVE equally (0.4%, N = 1). Unlike the English and Spanish CORPORA, no PROCESS was recorded for the THEME in the Persian CORPUS, which can be explained by its SOV WORD ORDER. In the Spanish CORPUS, the ordering from the third place onwards was as follows: PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE (21.3%, N = 55), ADVERBIAL GROUP (7.8%, N = 20), PROCESS (7%, N = 18), ‘THERE’ (3.1%, N = 8), PREDICATED THEME and EXTRAPOSITION (0.8%, N = 2) equally, and THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.4%, N = 1). There was no instance of the WH-ELEMENT in the English CORPUS, the PROCESS, PREDICATED THEME, and EXTRAPOSITION in the Persian CORPUS, or the MULTIPLE THEME, and WH-ELEMENT in the Spanish CORPUS as shown on Table 5.

Table 5. Comparative relative frequency of the THEME TYPES across the three languages

Theme Types	English Proverbs	Percentage	Persian Proverbs	Percentage	Spanish Proverbs	Percentage	Total Items	Total
Nominal Group	168	65.1%	163	63.2%	91	35.3%	422	54.6%
Clause	35	13.6%	53	20.5%	61	23.6%	149	19.3%
Prep. Phrase	6	2.3%	29	11.2%	55	21.3%	90	11.6%
Process	13	5.0%	0	0.0%	18	7.0%	31	4%
Adv. Group	6	2.3%	5	1.9%	20	7.8%	31	4%
There	10	3.9%	1	0.4%	8	3.1%	19	2.5%
Multi. Themes	9	3.5%	3	1.2%	0	0.0%	12	1.5%
Extraposition	7	2.7%	0	0.0%	2	0.8%	9	1.2%
Predicated Theme	3	1.2%	0	0.0%	2	0.8%	5	0.6%
Thematic Equative	1	0.4%	2	0.8%	1	0.4%	4	0.5%
WH-Element	0	0.0%	2	0.8%	0	0.0%	2	0.2%
Total	258	100%	258	100%	258	100%	774	100%

Viewed from a broader perspective, the results of the frequency of THEME TYPES show that the most frequent type is the NOMINAL GROUP. This suggests that NOMINAL GROUPS play a dominant role in initiating themes within the CLAUSES of the CORPUS. The second most common type is CLAUSE, indicating a significant proportion of THEMES are realized as FULL CLAUSES. PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES follow within a close distance, showing that THEMES often involve spatial or other relational expressions. Other THEME TYPES such as PROCESS, ADVERBIAL GROUPS, and ‘THERE’ occur less frequently. Additionally, MULTIPLE THEME and EXTRAPOSITION appear in even smaller percentages, highlighting their less common use in structuring THEMES. THEMATIC EQUATIVE and WH-ELEMENT appear to be relatively rare in the CORPUS. These results suggest that the majority of the CLAUSES in the CORPUS are initiated by NOMINAL and CLAUSAL THEMES, with other types serving more specialized functions.

The CHI-SQUARE TEST confirmed a significant association between language and THEME TYPE ($\chi^2 = 138.209 > \chi^2 \text{ CRITICAL} = 31.410$). PAIRWISE comparisons also showed significant relationships: English–Persian ($\chi^2 = 76.1369$), English–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 108.164$), and Persian–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 90.5612$), all exceeding the CRITICAL VALUE of 18.307.

3.3 Summary of the results of the analysis of the THEME SYSTEM in the proverbs and comparison with the results of previous studies

Following the presentation of the results from the analysis of the THEME TYPES in the previous section, here, I provide a comparison of these findings with those of a similar study, namely McCabe's (1999), as it is the only previous study that addresses the analysis of THEME TYPES interlingually. The results of the current analysis (Table 5) showed some common traits in all three CORPORA. Thus, for example, the first and the second most frequent THEME TYPES are the same and include: NOMINAL GROUP (65.1%, 63.2%, and 35.3%, in English, Persian, and Spanish, respectively) followed by CLAUSE (13.6%, 20.5%, and 23.6% in English, Persian, and Spanish, respectively). English and Persian resemble one another in terms of the frequency of the

NOMINAL GROUP more than they do in the Spanish CORPUS, while the Persian and Spanish are closer in terms of the frequency of clause. However, the third most dominant THEME TYPE in Persian and Spanish is the same, namely the PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE (11.2% and 21.3%, respectively), but in English, third place was occupied by PROCESS as the THEME (5%). The results showed that the ADVERBIAL GROUP occurred more frequently in Spanish (7.8%) than in either Persian or English (1.9% and 2.3%), respectively. Also, the PREDICATED THEME (1.2% and 0.8%) and EXTRAPOSITION (2.7% and 0.8%) only occurred in the English and Spanish CORPORA, respectively, without a single instance appearing in Persian. The absence of PROCESS as THEME in the Persian corpus is explained by its SOV WORD ORDER, while in English (5%) and Spanish (7%), PROCESS as THEME occupied third place and fifth place respectively. Another THEME TYPE, ‘THERE’, was found in both the English (3.9%) and the Spanish (3.1%) CORPORA with a close percentage, while this was not the case in the Persian *corpus* (0.4%). MULTIPLE THEME was another THEME TYPE that occurred only in the English (3.5%) and the Persian (1.2%) corpus. Some THEME TYPES did not occur in any of the three CORPORA, namely the WH-ELEMENT in the English and Spanish CORPORA, PROCESS, PREDICATED THEME, and EXTRAPOSITION in the Persian CORPUS, and MULTIPLE THEME, and WH-ELEMENT in the Spanish CORPUS.

In McCabe’s study (1999), the results revealed both similarities and differences when compared to those of this study regarding the dominance of certain THEME TYPES in the English and Spanish CORPORA. In McCabe’s study, the most frequently occurring THEME TYPES were as follows: NOMINAL GROUP (64.77% and 47.43%, in English and Spanish, respectively), PROCESS (6.15% and 18.29%), and ‘THERE’ (0.80% and 0.63%), where the only similarity with the current research is in terms of NOMINAL GROUP as the most frequent one. Other frequent THEME TYPES in her study such as CLAUSE (4.08% and 3.17%), WH-ELEMENT (1.40% and 0.24%), EXTRAPOSITION (0.67% and 2.53%), and THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.33% and 0.55%) do not either follow the same order of frequency of the THEME TYPES of this study.

4. Discussion

This section provides a QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS of the results obtained, structured around the three RESEARCH QUESTIONS formulated in this study:

RQ1. Do equivalent proverbs in different languages represent an interaction between the speaker and hearer in a similar way?

RQ2. Do equivalent proverbs in different languages organize the information within the sentence in the same way?

RQ3. Does a comparison of equivalent proverbs in different languages also reflect SOCIOCULTURAL SIMILARITIES and DIFFERENCES?

4.1 Discussion of mood types

When viewed in the light of RQ1 (Do equivalent proverbs in different languages represent an interaction between the speaker and hearer in a similar way?), this research shows that there are four TYPES OF MOOD in the proverbs: DECLARATIVE, IMPERATIVE, WH-INTERROGATIVE, and YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE. Each of these MOOD TYPES corroborates a distinct interaction between the addresser and the addressee. Thus, the DECLARATIVE MOOD is typically used to convey information, whereas the IMPERATIVE MOOD serves to prompt interaction between the speaker and the hearer, eliciting either a positive or negative response to a given command. The two INTERROGATIVE MOODS, the WH-INTERROGATIVE and the YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE, stimulate a response from the hearer proportionate to the type of interrogation. The percentage frequency of MOOD TYPES in the three CORPORA shows that the DECLARATIVE MOOD is the most prevalent in all three languages: 91.9% in English, 90.3% in Persian, and 89.5% in Spanish. This suggests a strong inclination in all three cultures to express general truths, wisdom, or advice in a direct, statement-based format. Following

the DECLARATIVE MOOD, the IMPERATIVE MOOD ranks second in all corpora, though with slight variation in frequency: 8.1% in English, 7.8% in Persian, and 10.5% in Spanish. This indicates that while the IMPERATIVE MOOD is less frequent than the DECLARATIVE, it still plays a significant role in conveying moral guidance, exhortations, and instructions in each language. The higher frequency of the IMPERATIVE in Spanish may reflect the language's tendency to use proverbs as a tool for direct engagement with the listener, encouraging action or caution. In contrast, the INTERROGATIVE MOOD is notably rare across the CORPORA, with only five instances of the WH-INTERROGATIVE MOOD, all of which are found in the Persian CORPUS (1.9%). Notably, there are no cases of YES/NO-INTERROGATIVE MOOD in any of the three CORPORA, highlighting a significant difference in the use of INTERROGATIVES in proverbs across these languages. The presence of the WH-INTERROGATIVE MOOD in Persian, albeit limited, may indicate a STYLISTIC or RHETORICAL PREFERENCE for inquiry as a means to provoke reflection or emphasize PARADOXES, a feature less prominent in English and Spanish proverbs.

In summary, all three CORPORA tend to favor the DECLARATIVE MOOD, followed by the IMPERATIVE, explaining their similar frequency counts. INTERPERSONALLY, they are more INFORMATIONALLY than INTERACTIVELY ORIENTED. The only exception was the Persian CORPUS, where five instances of WH-INTERROGATIVES suggest a slightly more INTERACTIVE ORIENTATION than English or Spanish.

The analysis of MOOD TYPES in English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs supports H1, indicating that languages share resources for enacting social relations via the MOOD SYSTEM. DECLARATIVE and IMPERATIVE MOODS were similarly used across the CORPORA, with DECLARATIVES conveying information and IMPERATIVES prompting interaction. CHI-SQUARE TESTS confirmed CORRELATIONS between languages, though the English–Spanish link was weaker, suggesting possible LINGUISTIC or CULTURAL VARIATION. Overall, equivalent proverbs tend to employ similar GRAMMATICAL STRATEGIES to achieve comparable INTERACTIONAL EFFECTS.

4.2 Discussion of Theme types

The analysis of THEME and RHEME presented in Section 3.2.5 deserves to be discussed in relation to RQ2 (Do equivalent proverbs in different languages organize the information within the sentence in the same way?). Firstly, this research has investigated 11 TYPES OF THEME in the three CORPORA including: NOMINAL GROUP, PROCESS, CLAUSE, ADVERBIAL GROUP, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE, THERE, THEMATIC EQUATIVE, PREDICATED THEME, EXTRAPOSITION, MULTIPLE THEME, and WH-ELEMENT. In all three CORPORA, the most dominant THEME TYPES were the NOMINAL GROUP and the CLAUSE. The NOMINAL GROUP emerged as the leading THEME TYPE in both English (65.1%) and Persian (63.2%), while it was less frequent in the Spanish CORPUS (35.3%). This suggests that English and Persian proverbs tend to begin with a NOMINAL ELEMENT, often focusing on a SUBJECT or concept that sets the tone for the proverb's message. This result bears out Halliday's remark that "*the most common type of Theme is a participant realized by a nominal group*" (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 91). The clause also ranked highly in all three CORPORA, with English (13.6%) and Persian (20.5%) showing a similar preference for clauses as THEMES, while Spanish proverbs exhibited a higher frequency of CLAUSES (23.6%). This may reflect a greater tendency in Spanish proverbs to use more COMPLEX STRUCTURES or CLAUSES to convey a complete thought or idea. In other words, the dominance of CLAUSE in the proverbs in the three languages tend to emphasize an idea, fact, or view (complement clause) by complementing a VERB, ADJECTIVE or NOUN, a quality of something (*relative clause*) through a RELATIVE PRONOUN or a RELATIVE ADVERB, and a CIRCUMSTANCE (ADVERBIAL CLAUSE) by modifying a VERB, an ADJECTIVE or another ADVERB.

The remaining THEME TYPES were less uniformly distributed across the CORPORA. In the English CORPUS, THEMES such as PROCESS (5%), 'THERE' (3.9%), and MULTIPLE THEME (3.5%) appeared, followed by EXTRAPOSITION (2.7%), ADVERBIAL GROUP and PREPOSITIONAL PHRASE (2.3%) equally, with PREDICATED THEME (1.2%) and THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.4%) occurring less frequently. These results suggest that English proverbs tend to favor more straightforward THEMATIC STRUCTURES, with occasional use of PROCESS and

ADVERBIAL ELEMENTS for specific emphasis or emphasis on action. The Persian CORPUS, on the other hand, demonstrated a notable frequency of PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES (11.2%) following NOMINAL GROUPS and CLAUSES. Other THEME TYPES included ADVERBIAL GROUPS (1.9%), MULTIPLE THEMES (1.2%), and WH-ELEMENTS and THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.8%) equally, with the ‘THERE’ THEME appearing least frequently (0.4%). This indicates a greater emphasis in Persian proverbs on RELATIONAL THEMES, marked by the use of PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES, as well as a higher frequency of ADVERBIAL GROUPS. In the Spanish CORPUS, PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES (21.3%) were the second most frequent THEME TYPE after the NOMINAL GROUP, with ADVERBIAL GROUPS (7.8%) also occurring prominently. Additionally, PROCESS THEMES (7%) appeared, suggesting a slight tendency towards actions or events. The distribution of other THEME TYPES, such as ‘THERE’ (3.1%), PREDICATED THEME and EXTRAPOSITION (0.8%), and THEMATIC EQUATIVE (0.4%), was less frequent, reflecting a more varied approach to THEMATIC STRUCTURE compared to the English and Persian CORPORA.

The findings differ a little from McCabe’s (1999) regarding the order of the most dominant THEME TYPES. For example, in the three CORPORA the most dominant THEME TYPES in this study are NOMINAL GROUP and CLAUSE, while in McCabe’s, they are: NOMINAL GROUP (64.77% and 47.43% in English and Spanish), PROCESS (6.15% and 18.29% in English and Spanish), CLAUSE (4.08% and 3.17% in English and Spanish), ‘THERE’ (0.80% and 0.63% in English and Spanish), EXTRAPOSITION (0.67% and 2.53% in English and Spanish), WH-ELEMENT (1.40% and 0.24% in English and Spanish).

In conclusion, the correlation between THEME TYPES and language use in English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs reveals both SHARED STRUCTURES and distinct LINGUISTIC PREFERENCES. While NOMINAL GROUPS and CLAUSES are common across all three, English favors PROCESSES, Persian emphasizes RELATIONAL MEANING through PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES, and Spanish shows a preference for PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES and ADVERBIAL GROUPS. These patterns reflect each language’s COMMUNICATIVE PRIORITIES and CULTURAL FRAMING of wisdom.

4.3 Discussion of the Correlation between thematic progression and mood realization contributing to sociocultural variation in proverb interpretation

RQ3 (Does a comparison of equivalent proverbs in different languages reflect SOCIOCULTURAL SIMILARITIES and DIFFERENCES?) seeks to investigate the correlation between LINGUISTIC and SOCIOCULTURAL SIMILARITIES and DIFFERENCES across the three languages. While it is true that LINGUISTICALLY the analysis of the elements in the MOOD and THEME SYSTEMS shows more similarities than differences in the proverbs in the three languages, the results also appear to reveal some small differences in each language in relation to the INTERPERSONAL and TEXTUAL METAFUNCTIONS.

The MOOD SYSTEM analysis shows that all three CORPORA predominantly use DECLARATIVE MOODS, followed by IMPERATIVES, suggesting a balance of INFORMATIONAL and INTERACTIVE ORGANIZATION. This similarity indicates that equivalent proverbs often adopt the same mood to convey meaning. A notable exception is the Persian corpus, which includes five WH-INTERROGATIVES—highlighting a slightly stronger INTERACTIVE ORIENTATION compared to English and Spanish.

In English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs, THEMES are mainly expressed through NOMINAL GROUPS and CLAUSES, especially in English and Persian, reflecting a preference for abstract reasoning and general truths. Spanish shows a more balanced use, with frequent PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES, suggesting a cultural tendency toward relational and CONTEXT-SPECIFIC EXPRESSION of wisdom.

In conclusion, the LINGUISTIC PATTERNS found in English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs offer evidence supporting H3—that SHARED and DIVERGENT FEATURES reflect meaningful cultural traits. However, further research is needed to draw stronger conclusions about the CULTURAL PARALLELS and DIFFERENCES expressed through their PROVERBIAL DISCOURSE.

5. Conclusion

The comparative analysis of English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs reveals both LINGUISTIC and CULTURAL PARALLELS and DISTINCTIONS. While the two METAFUNCTIONS show more commonalities than differences—especially in the use of DECLARATIVE and IMPERATIVE MOODS—variations in THEME TYPES reflect subtle CULTURAL NUANCES and DIVERGENT WORLDVIEWS.

The dominance of DECLARATIVE and IMPERATIVE MOODS in English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs reflects a shared cultural preference for direct, DIDACTIC EXPRESSION of moral truths and advice. DECLARATIVES assert wisdom as fact, while IMPERATIVES guide behavior. Persian proverbs, however, uniquely feature WH-INTERROGATIVES, suggesting a more dialogical, reflective style rooted in its SOCIOCULTURAL VALUES—less evident in the more straightforward English and Spanish counterparts.

In English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs, THEMES are typically expressed through NOMINAL GROUPS and CLAUSES, especially in English and Persian, reflecting a shared focus on abstract ideas and clear PARTICIPANTS. This may stem from cultural traditions valuing individual agency and philosophical reflection. Spanish proverbs, however, show a more balanced use of NOMINAL GROUPS, CLAUSES, and PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES, indicating a preference for RELATIONAL and CONTEXT-BASED EXPRESSION rooted in DIALOGIC COMMUNICATION.

While English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs share LINGUISTIC FEATURES, differences in MOOD and THEMATIC STRUCTURE reveal distinct CULTURAL VALUES and worldviews, supporting the idea that language reflects CULTURAL EXPRESSION. The analysis shows that, despite STRUCTURAL SIMILARITIES, each language's proverbs embody unique SOCIOCULTURAL TRAITS, affirming that language is UNIVERSALLY FUNCTIONAL yet deeply rooted in its cultural context.

Future research could incorporate theories like APPRAISAL THEORY for deeper intralingual analysis or apply CARDIFF GRAMMAR to compare results across models. Expanding the cultural comparison of proverbs

in English, Persian, and Spanish may offer further insights, while including non-Indo-European languages such as Chinese or Japanese could enrich CROSS-CULTURAL UNDERSTANDING.

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